



ASSEMBLY
Elections 08

are a familiar sight in Delhi's middle-class Punjabi circuit. He also has sterling electoral credentials. In 1999, he defeated Manmohan Singh from South Delhi. Malhotra may not have the savvy of a Manmohan or a Dikshit but the BJP is hoping that his grave and courteous demeanour will pass off for mass appeal as he tries to whip up a decade of discontent against Dikshit.

As a challenger, the 78-year-old Malhotra is a steady plodder; but one who remains focused. He has governed Delhi before as the city's chief executive councillor—the equivalent of today's chief minister—but that was nearly 40 years ago. Dikshit has the advantage—and the disadvantage—of instant recall. She talks of continuity of her development work and of the idea of a Delhi she represents. Dressed in simple black cotton saris, she watches movies like *Welcome to Sajjanpur* and has Tich Nhat Hanh's works for bedtime reading. Very grandmother next-door. And very PLU (People Like Us). The image has worked as she reached out to Delhi's middle-class with her Bhagidari scheme. But this is also an image she has stretched for over 10 years now. Moreover, not all her projects are successful and as the traffic snarls pile up because of the badly implemented Bus Rapid Transit corridor, Malhotra seizes his chance. "I will not undo everything but bottle-

THE FACE-OFF



V.K. MALHOTRA,
Greater Kailash

The Congress has not named its chief ministerial candidate yet. Sheilaji is still not designated as the candidate.

She has done nothing in the last 10 years for the city. The people of Delhi want change.

I allocated Rs 4 crore for the Metro project in 1970. The older generation remembers what I did.

One of the first things I will do is to clear the Afzal Guru file. The Congress is soft on terror.

I built the first three flyovers in Delhi, regularised 26% of the unauthorised colonies and cleaned the Yamuna.



SHEILA DIKSHIT,
New Delhi

The Congress never announces its candidate. Why state the obvious? I lead the campaign. Our MLAs will later decide.

It's not anti-incumbency but pro-incumbency. I have been CM for 10 years. They have changed three CMs in five years.

Which older Delhiite says the city is not comfortable to live in? What happened to the Metro when they came to power?

The attack on the Parliament happened on their watch. We're not the ones who escorted terrorists to Kandahar.

We've reduced power losses from 56% to 26%. From 1,900 MW of power in 1998, we now generate over 4,000 MW.

DIVIDE TO RULE

Mayawati announced her candidates for Delhi way back in September and has planned five rallies in the capital. She could woo away a chunk of the Congress votebank. In the municipal polls last year, BSP polled an impressive 10 per cent and won 15 wards.

necks are not development," he said.

Dikshit tosses this aside with a smile that would do a Vietnamese Zen master proud. But six months ago, that smile was not so calm, the people of Delhi not so tolerant of status quo, inflation and potholes.

Dikshit herself was on edge, making a series of statements that angered Bihari migrants and working girls. Statements that jarred against her politically correct decade. "There was a perception in the past few months that the people wanted a

change but now they have come back to development and social equality," she analyses. It could be the search for stability but in the last month the capital once again seems to be in a mood to embrace Dikshit. She may even pull off a personal coup and win the capital for the third time but even that is a road fraught with danger. The Congress is not so tolerant of leaders whose personal charisma outshines the party. If she manages to defeat Malhotra, her real battle will only have begun. ■